

stability around home ownership. Cathie talked about understanding the consequences of the choice to re-mortgage her home—she understood she could lose her home, and she and her now husband, Stuart Giles, had to decide whether this was something they could live with.

I believe the reason Jacqui and Cathie both initially defaulted to their parents' Money Stories is because the financial behaviours were modelled to them from a young age by people they both looked up to. A scenario that would be familiar to so many of us. But the reason both these women rejected them was because they recognised they were Money Stories that were no longer serving them.

The Money Story you inherited or received may be different. It's important to recognise and understand what that Money Story is and to ask whether as an adult it's something you need to accept, reject or tweak for yourself. To take Brené's quote at face value—it's acknowledging your Money Story, owning it and deciding if you want to choose to write a brave new ending.

Once we start to recognise our Money Stories we might realise they are being told to us by voices in our heads that aren't necessarily kind. Or flattering. Or helpful. Some of the stories are in the voices of people from our past, from our family or from peers. Or, if you're like me, the most critical voice might be your own.

How do you calm those voices down? By acknowledging what they're saying and where they come from, then turning down their volume. Way, way down.

That's often easier said than done. Sometimes it can feel easier to dig your head in the sand or grit your teeth and keep going. That's because if you're anything like me, you may not love peeking into your past. I mean, it's understandable—there's a whole lot there I'm not comfortable looking at and it takes a whole boatload of courage and vulnerability to look at it and recognise its effect. But this is where Brené's words ring true for me—by denying the story of who I am, where I've come from and what I've lived through, it has defined me without my being aware of it. And that includes financially. The truth is that definition hasn't always been pretty.

Why is that the case? To explain further, let me tell you a little bit about my Money Story.